Living conditions in Europe - poverty and social exclusion

Statistics Explained

Data extracted in: April 2025
Planned article update: April 2027

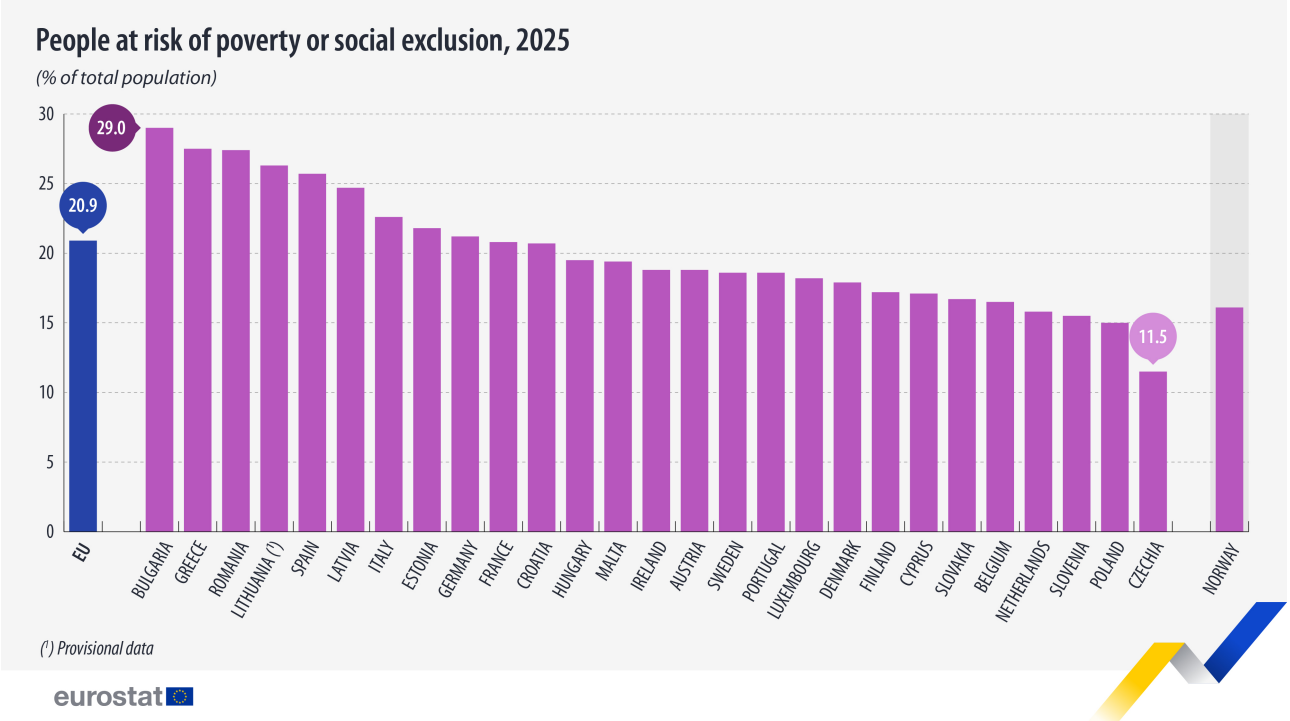
Highlights

In 2025, 92.7 million people in the EU were at risk of poverty or social exclusion; this was equivalent to 20.9% of the EU population.

The risk of poverty or social exclusion in the EU was, in 2025, higher for women than for men (21.9% compared with 19.8%).

In 2025, at the EU level, working status significantly influenced the at-risk-of-poverty-or-social-exclusion rate, ranging from 10.9% for employed people to 66.3% for the unemployed individuals.

Over one-fifth (22.1%) of the EU population living in households with dependent children was at risk of poverty or social exclusion in 2025.



Source: Eurostat (ilc_peps01n)

This article is part of a set of statistical articles that form Eurostat's online publication, *Living conditions in Europe* and focuses on people at risk of poverty or social exclusion , presenting some key results from the European Union's (EU) statistics on income and living conditions (EU-SILC) . This data collection covers EU countries, as well as most of the EFTA and candidate countries .

Poverty or social exclusion

Over one in five people in the EU were at risk of poverty or social exclusion

In 2025, there were around 92.7 million people in the EU at risk of poverty or social exclusion, which was equivalent to 20.9% of the total population. The AROPE rate varied considerably across the EU countries. Bulgaria (29.0%), Greece (27.5%) and Romania (27.4%) reported the highest shares of people at risk of poverty or social exclusion in 2025. By contrast, the Netherlands, Slovenia, Poland and Czechia presented shares below 16.0%.

Component indicators which contribute to an analysis of the risk of poverty or social exclusion

Figure 1 provides an analysis for the EU population of the various components of risks of poverty or social exclusion. Among the 92.7 million people within the EU who faced the risk of poverty or social exclusion in 2025, some 5.7 million lived in households experiencing simultaneously all 3 poverty and social exclusion risks. There were 11.6 million people in the EU living both at risk of poverty and in a household with very low work intensity (but not severely materially and socially deprived); 8.1 million were at risk of poverty and at the same time severely materially and socially deprived (but not in a household with very low work intensity); almost 1.5 million lived in households with very low work intensity while experiencing severe material deprivation (but were not at risk of poverty).

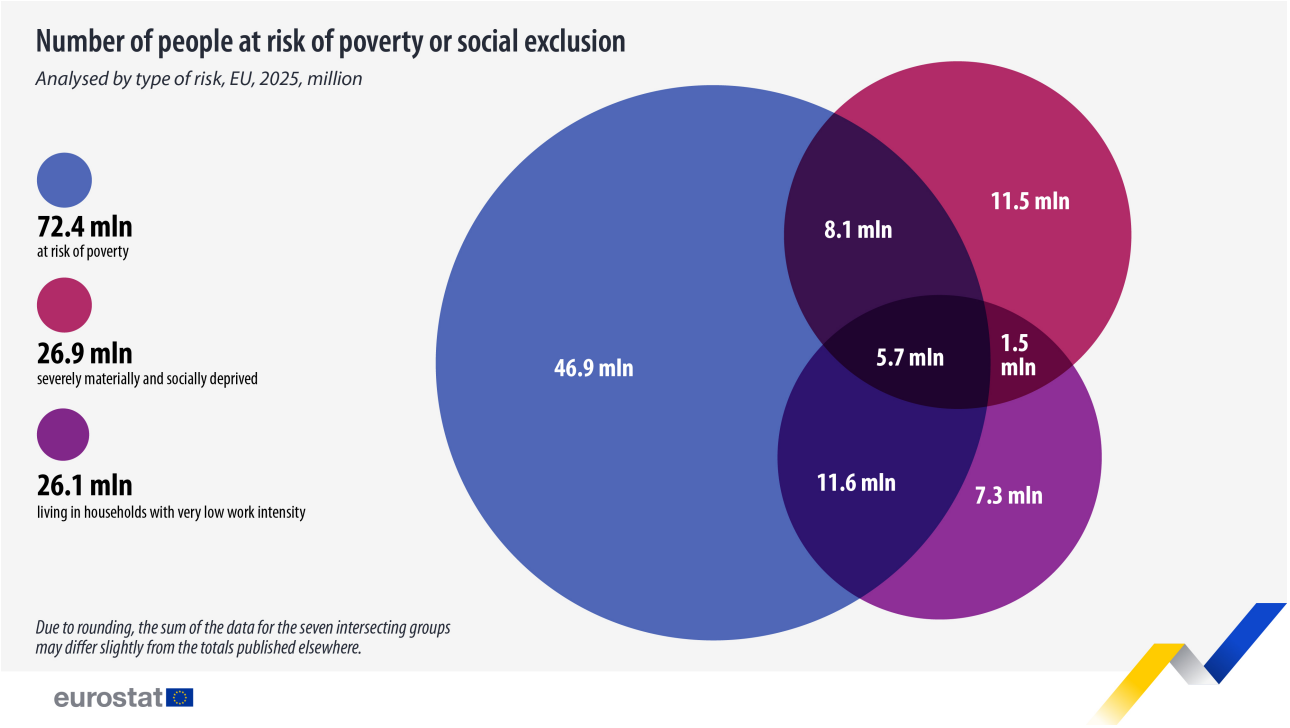


Figure 1: Number of people at risk of poverty or social exclusion, by type of risk, EU, 2025 Source: Eurostat (ilc_pees01n)

The profile of people in the EU at risk of poverty or social exclusion

Women, young adults aged 18-24 years, people with a low level of educational attainment and unemployed people were, on average, more likely to be at risk of poverty or social exclusion in 2025 than other groups within the EU population (see **Figure 2**).

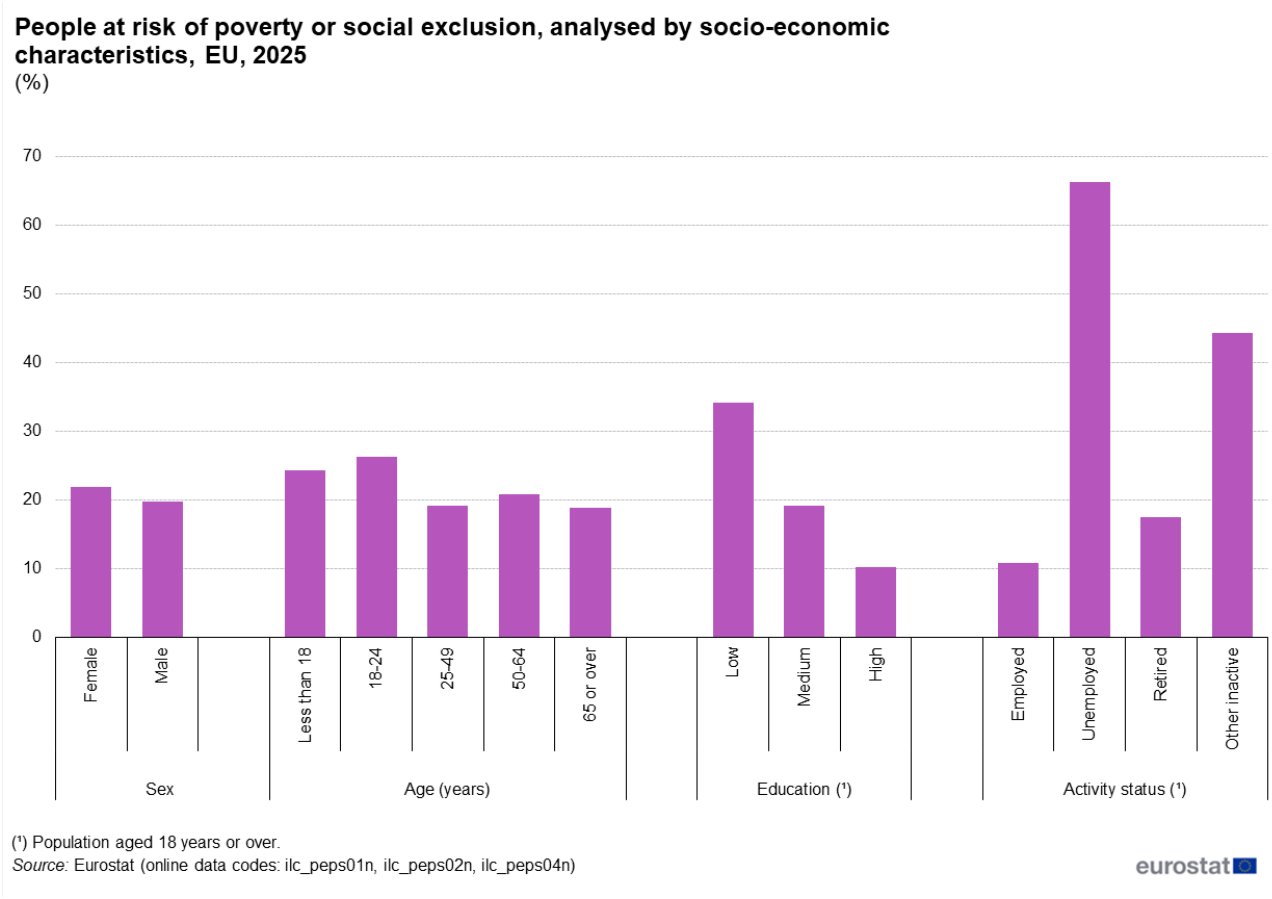


Figure 2: People at risk of poverty or social exclusion, by socio-economic characteristics, EU, 2025 Source: Eurostat (ilc_peps01n), (ilc_peps02n) and (ilc_peps04n)

Women and young adults were more at risk of poverty or social exclusion

When analyzed by sex, the risk of poverty or social exclusion in the EU was higher for women than it was for men (21.9% compared with 19.8%).

Concerning age, the highest risk of poverty or social exclusion in the EU was recorded for young adults aged 18-24 years (26.3%), while the lowest risk was recorded for adults aged 65 years or over (18.8%). Moreover, the risk of poverty or social exclusion was 19.1% for adults aged 25-49 years and 20.8% among the population aged 50-64 years. The youngest age group, people aged less than 18 years, recorded a relatively high risk of poverty or social exclusion (24.3%).

In addition to age, educational attainment had a considerable impact on the risk of poverty or social exclusion

At EU level, more than one-third (34.2%) of all people aged 18 years or over with a low educational attainment level (International Standard Classification of Education (ISCED) levels 0-2) were at risk of poverty or social exclusion, compared with 10.3% of people in the same age group with a tertiary (high) level of educational attainment (ISCED levels 5-8). The corresponding percentage for people with a medium level of educational attainment (ISCED levels 3-4) was 19.2%.

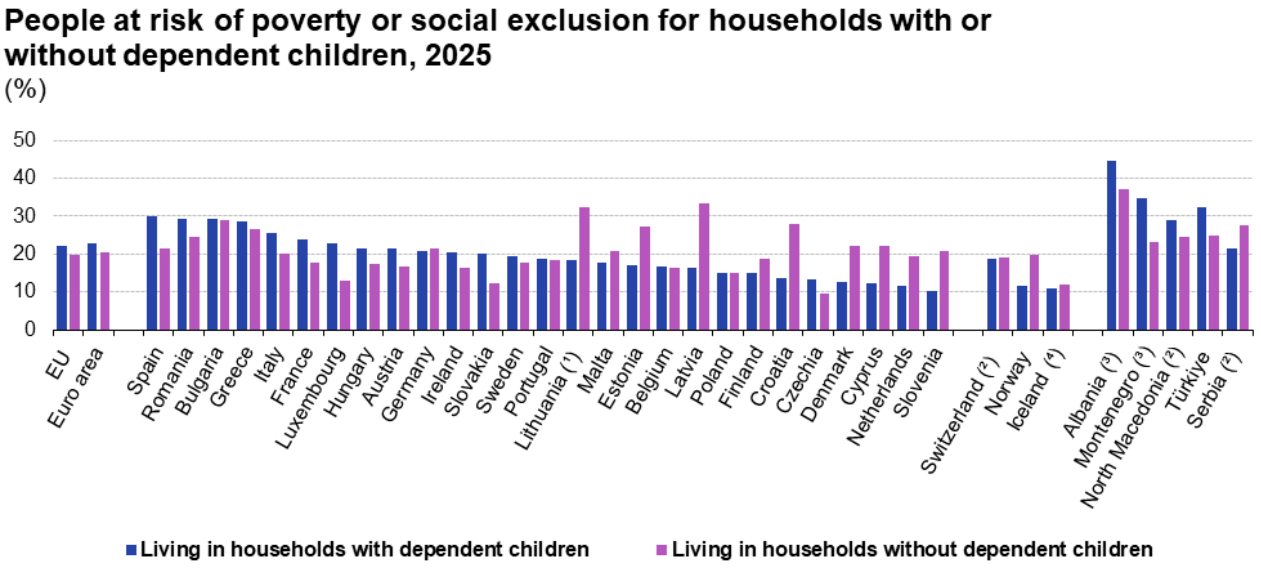
Unemployed people faced a particularly high risk of poverty or social exclusion

In the EU, 66.3% of the unemployed aged 18 years or over were at risk of poverty or social exclusion in 2025. Inactive people (other than in retirement) faced the second-highest risk on the basis of an analysis by activity status, with 44.3% at risk. For comparison, the share of people in retirement who were at risk of poverty or social

exclusion was 17.6% and the share of employed people in such situation was 10.9%.

At the EU level, households with dependent children faced a slightly higher risk of poverty or social exclusion than those without

More than one-fifth (22.1%) of people living in households with dependent children in the EU were at risk of poverty or social exclusion which was slightly higher than the respective share among households without dependent children (19.8%). Nevertheless, these rates varied considerably across the EU countries. For people living in households with dependent children, the rate ranged from peaks of 29.9% in Spain, 29.4% in Romania and 29.1% in Bulgaria down to 12.2% in Cyprus, 11.7% in the Netherlands and 10.4% in Slovenia (see **Figure 3**). For those living in households without dependent children, the rates varied from 33.4% in Latvia, 32.3% in Lithuania and 28.9% in Bulgaria to 12.8% in Luxembourg, 12.3% in Slovakia and 9.6% in Czechia.



Note: ranked on households with dependent children.
(1) Provisional.
(2) 2024 data.
(3) 2023 data.
(4) 2020 data.
Source: Eurostat (online data code: ilc_peps03n)

eurostat

Figure 3: People at risk of poverty or social exclusion for households with or without dependent children, 2025 Source: Eurostat (ilc_peps03n)

Source data for tables and graphs

- Poverty and social exclusion: tables and figures

Data sources

The data used in this article are derived from the statistics on income and living conditions (EU-SILC) data collection. EU-SILC data are compiled annually and are the main source of statistics that measure income and living conditions in Europe; it is also the main source of information used to link different aspects relating to the quality of life of households and individuals.

The reference population for the information presented in this article is all private households and their current members residing in the territory of an EU Member State (or non-EU member country) at the time of data collection; people living in collective households and in institutions are generally excluded from the target

population. The data for the EU are population-weighted averages of national data.

The data on educational attainment levels is collected and classified according to ISCED 2011 . It is divided into three categories: high (short-cycle tertiary education, bachelor's or equivalent, master's or equivalent, and doctoral or equivalent levels), medium (upper secondary and post-secondary non-tertiary education), and low (less than primary, primary, or lower secondary education).

Context

The at risk of poverty or social exclusion rate, abbreviated as AROPE, corresponds to the sum of people who are either at risk of poverty , or severely materially and socially deprived or living in a household with a very low work intensity (also know as (quasi-)jobless households). The AROPE ratio is the share of the total population which is at risk of poverty or social exclusion. The headline target (EU2030 target) on poverty and social inclusion of the European Pillar of Social Rights Action Plan is to reduce the number of people at risk of poverty or social exclusion by at least 15 million by 2030. Progress towards this target is monitored through the AROPE rate, published by Eurostat.

To calculate the number or share of people at risk of poverty or social exclusion, three separate measures are combined. This indicator covers individuals who are in at least one of the following situations:

• **People at risk of poverty** , that is, those with an equivalised disposable income below the at-risk-of-poverty threshold, defined as 60% of the national median equivalised disposable income after social transfers;

• **People experiencing severe material and social deprivation** , that is, those who face and enforced lack at least seven out of thirteen deprivation items (six related to the individual and seven related to the household) considered necessary and desirable for an adequate life;

• **People aged less than 65 years living in households with very low work intensity** , that is, those living in households where the adults (those aged 18-64, but excluding students aged 18-24 and people who are retired according to their self-defined current economic status or who receive any pension (except survivors pension), as well as people in the age bracket 60-64 who are inactive and living in a household where the main income is pensions) worked a working time equal or less than 20% of their total combined work-time potential during the previous year.

In 2021, the AROPE indicator was modified. The severe material deprivation rate component was revised, defining a new severe material and social deprivation rate (SMSD) based on a revised list of items, and the people living in very low work intensity households indicator relating to people living in a household with a very low work intensity was redefined. The revised AROPE indicator is used to monitor the headline target on poverty and social inclusion of the European Pillar of Social Rights Action Plan.

Explore further

Other articles

- All articles from*Living conditions in Europe*
- EU statistics on income and living conditions (EU-SILC) methodology - people at risk of poverty or social exclusion
- Living conditions in Europe - income distribution and income inequality

Database

- Income and living conditions - detailed datasets (ilc)

Thematic section

- Income, social inclusion and living conditions

Publications

- Key figures on European living conditions – 2025 edition - Eurostat

Methodology

- Income and living conditions (ESMS metadata file — ilc_esms)
- Income and living conditions — information on data
- Income and living conditions — methodology

Legislation

- European Commission — Directorate General for Employment, Social Affairs & Inclusion: Indicators' Sub-Group of the Social Protection Committee
- European Commission — Directorate General for Employment, Social Affairs & Inclusion: Employment and social analysis

External links

- European Commission — Directorate General for Employment, Social Affairs & Inclusion: Indicators' Sub-Group of the Social Protection Committee
- European Commission — Directorate General for Employment, Social Affairs & Inclusion: Employment and social analysis